forces on a large scale in the border areas with China. Tens of thousands of troops with accompanying equipment were rapidly airlifted in a decisive step. This was in response to Chinese military movements that violated our long-standing agreements. Not just that, thereafter, fashioning a diplomatic posture to convey the abnormality in our ties in a sustained manner was no small matter.

Then, there was the establishment of the Quad and its steady growth, both in protocol terms and agenda. This, too, was taken forward despite strong pressures to desist. I have already made a reference to the call taken in Bangkok to not join the RCEP. When it came to oil purchases from Russia, India was being publicly pressurized by those who had softened the consequences for themselves. Each of this was decided by putting the interests of India first.

There were also occasions that involved larger concerns of a regional or global nature. One was to take the call to supply vaccines to the Global South even when vaccination was ongoing in India. Another was the scale and speed with which India responded to Sri Lanka's pressing economic needs. Interestingly, when the I2U2 and India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) initiatives were tabled, we surprised our other partners by the swiftness of our response, precisely because our analysis of the region anticipated their coming.

An early exhortation within the Modi government was to get the world to change its thinking about India. This meant building and demonstrating capabilities across a wide spectrum. It required us to be involved in key global debates and be perceived more as part of the solution than the problem. Another expectation was that India would assume greater responsibilities and make stronger contributions. From our side, we strove for better understanding of the various dimensions of transformation of our society. Our endeavour was also to establish India as a more credible and trusted partner. Each of these factors became an input into the influence game that characterizes international relations. Bringing them all together means creating a different narrative, one that captures the progress while articulating the future. This is very much central to the projection of the message of a New India.

The diplomacy of a major country is very arduous, even more so when it is a rising power. Leadership and conceptual clarity may make it easier to be executed. But arriving at a comprehensive vision and refreshing that